

Our reference: OMB-160075-Q0H1W8
30 October 2025

Mr Cian Mac Liatháin
2 Willow Park
Shantalla
Galway H91 X8KK

Dear Mr Mac Liatháin,

I am writing to you about your complaint concerning the University of Galway. Having carried out an investigation, I have decided to not uphold your complaint. I have set out the reasons for my decision below.

Your complaint

You submitted an application to register for a Professional Masters in Education/Máistir Gairmiúil san Oideaches at the University of Galway (UG) in June 2025. UG refused your application. You contend the decision to refuse your application was unfair as it was not based on merit and you allege the decision was based on rumour and slander. You appealed this decision, and UG upheld its original decision. You contend this decision was unfair.

University of Galway's position

I asked UG to provide a report to this office based on your complaint. In response UG say:

17 June 2025 – You submitted a completed application for the MGO.

18 June 2025 – You were contacted via email to submit a subject declaration form. UG state you did not submit this.

24 June 2025 – A decision was made to refuse your application. The decision was made by the School of Education Team and administered by the Admission Coordinator in the College of Arts, Social Sciences and Celtic Studies.

24 June 2025 – You contacted the President of University of Galway, the Dean of Students and staff in the School of Education about this decision.

25 June 2025 – You were advised to make a formal appeal to the Deputy President and Registrar, Professor Becky Whay as per the Admissions Processes outlined. Prof Whay reviewed the decision and did not uphold your appeal.

Criteria used to assess MGO applications

Undergraduate degree performance: To be considered, applicants must have an overall minimum grade of H2.2 with an eligible Level 8 degree (or equivalent) on the National Framework of Qualifications (NFQ). Evidence of this must be provided in the form of an official university transcript or certification.

Relevant Professional Experience: A completed signed and stamped work experience form is required to validate any work experience obtained within an educational institution.

Additional relevant qualifications: Additional relevant completed academic qualifications are also taken into consideration as part of the application process, but suitable certificates must be provided to validate any completed qualifications.

Completed subject declaration forms: A subject declaration form for each subject that an applicant wishes to teach must be completed, signed and submitted as part of the application. The forms are issued by the Teaching Council of Ireland for the purposes of assessing eligibility to teach subjects at a post primary level.

Personal statement/CVs: Both personal statements and CV information will be taken into consideration if provided as part of an application. Points/weightings are issued to applicants with suitable undergraduate degrees, as well as relevant professional experience and additional relevant academic qualifications. This is important when ranking applications as the programme must place a limit on places for some teaching subjects.

Rationale for declining your application.

1. You already hold a teaching qualification with a first-class honours degree in the Bachelor of Arts (Mathematics and Education). The main benefit of completing the MGO is to qualify as a second level teacher which is a qualification you already have.
2. You expressed your interest via the personal statement letter in the application to teach Coding at Junior Cycle and Computer Science at Senior Cycle. There are two modules listed as follows under “Curriculum Information” on the course page that you refer to that would fulfil the desired learning outcomes.

Module detail under “Curriculum Information” on every course page is pulled through from Akari which is the curriculum software the University currently uses. Placeholder modules are set up on this system that are then pulled through to the course page and cannot be manually amended. There is a disclaimer above the “Curriculum Information” title that says Curriculum information relates to the current academic year (in most cases). Course and module offerings and details may be subject to change. In this particular case, these computer science modules have never actually been offered on the MGO and will not be offered for the coming year.

Role of the Ombudsman

The role of the Ombudsman is to ensure that public service providers deal with individuals properly, fairly and impartially. He seeks to ensure that public service providers act in a reasonable manner, taking all relevant factors into consideration. The Ombudsman cannot examine matters that relate to academic judgement. Please see the Ombudsman’s definition of academic judgement below.

“Academic judgement is a judgement that is made about a matter where only the opinion of the academic expert is sufficient. In addition, academic Judgement also includes ‘not any judgment made by an academic; it is a judgment that is made about a matter where the opinion of an academic expert is essential. So, for example this includes a judgment about marks awarded,

degree classification, research methodology, whether feedback is correct or adequate, and the content or outcomes of a course will normally involve academic judgement”

Analysis

In carrying out my investigation of your complaint I considered the points you raised and the UG’s response.

UG have confirmed it considered your application in line with the criteria used to assess MGO applications. UG gave two reasons as its rationale for refusing your application. The first being that the purpose of the MGO was to lead to a teaching qualification which you already have. The second related to information included in your personal statement which stated that you would like to complete a degree based on teaching coding at junior level and computer science at senior cycle.

UG have confirmed neither of these modules were offered for this academic year. There is a note under Curriculum Information on the module page that states *“Curriculum information relates to the current academic year (in most cases). Course and module offerings and details may be subject to change”*. There is also a note on the bottom of the module page which states that Module offerings and details may be subject to change. UG have also confirmed neither of these modules have ever been taught on the MGO. UG sent you an email on 24 June 2025 advising you of the reasons for its decision.

As noted above and previously, this Office is unable to investigate decisions taken by Public Service Bodies where they are based on academic judgement. I consider UG’s decision to refuse your application for the MGO to meet the Ombudsman’s definition for academic judgement and as a result I am not in a position to pursue this matter any further with UG. The Ombudsman’s role in this complaint is therefore limited to examining if the Public Service Body, in this case UG, followed its administrative processes and dealt with you appropriately and reasonably in their communications. UG have provided the criteria to be applied for assessing applications and suitability for this course. I consider that UG have processed your application in accordance with the acceptance criteria, and can find nothing in their communications with you, or their administrative actions, to suggest that they dealt with your application in an unfair or unreasonable way. As stated above, I cannot examine UG’s decision to refuse your application. Based on the above information I cannot uphold your complaint.

Conclusions

I appreciate that you may be disappointed, but based on all the information available to me, I am not able to pursue the case with the University of Galway. I will close the file on your complaint.

Finally, I would like to thank you very much for bringing this complaint to our attention. Complaints raised with public service providers and the Ombudsman help to identify any failings in procedures and to improve services.

Yours sincerely,

Peter Hardiman
Investigator